29

Walk before you can run

In each field of reform (e.g., land market) there are many things that need to be done. In what order should they be done? This is the sequencing question.

Sequencing discussions in India often degenerate into choosing low hanging fruit to begin the work, and proclaiming that an important reform has begun. Sophisticated thinking on sequencing involves five elements:

1. Capacity building in the policy process: We have shown seven elements of the policy pipeline. There is a natural sequencing, going from left to right, of the order in which actions should be undertaken.
2. Prerequisites: When *x* is a prerequisite for *y*, we have to get *x* in place before *y*.
3. Learning by doing: Start with simple problems, learn public management, and gradually escalate complexity.
4. Political economy considerations: Weigh the gains and the costs imposed by various alternative components, and take the ones with high economic gain but low political cost first. Early moves should create a constituency for the late moves. Early moves should not walk into a political economy trap.
5. Stinginess: Start on a low scale on coercive power and spending, escalate only when capabilities are proven.